

ALERT TO DANGER

Red kangaroos usually browse and graze head down, but remain alert, looking and listening for predators. Their sharp eyes can spot a dingo 1,150 ft (350 m) away, and their large ears are very sensitive.

*Osphranter rufus***Red kangaroo**

Location Australia

Length 2¼–4½ ft
(0.7–1.4 m)

Tail 25–39 ft
(64–100 cm)

Weight 37–200 lb
(17–92 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



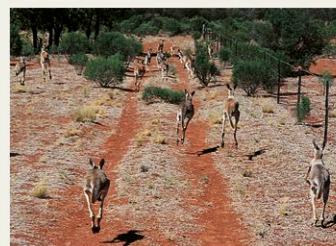
The largest living marsupial, the red kangaroo is found over much of Australia, with the highest numbers living in open savanna woodland. Its population varies greatly from year to year: when rainfall is high, numbers may reach as many as 12 million, falling to 5 million in times of drought. Females will conceive only if there has been enough rain to produce plenty of green vegetation. In a prolonged drought, the males no longer produce sperm. Red kangaroos use a highly developed sense of smell to detect water, and if it is scarce will migrate up to 125 miles (200 km) from their usual grazing grounds to find it. They forage mainly at night, eating succulent grass shoots, herbs, and leaves. Groups frequently change composition and size. They may hold as many as 25 individuals but the average group size is 2 to 3, although 1,500 or so may gather at a water hole during a drought. The dominant male of the group mates with several females. The red kangaroo is regarded as a pest in its native Australia, and is hunted for its meat and skin. Apart from humans and occasionally the wedge-tailed eagle, its only predator is the dingo.

DEFENSIVE MEASURES

The dominant male of a group of red kangaroos will fight off any challenge for supremacy from other males. If one of a group spies a potential predator, it will warn the rest by stamping its foot or thumping its tail on the ground. The group will then flee, taking refuge in water if possible.

**PLAY FIGHTING**

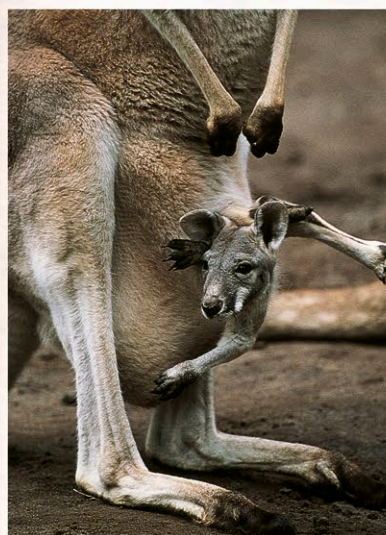
When playing or fighting among themselves, kangaroos may stand up and spar, but their normal defense is to deliver a powerful kick.

**IN FULL FLIGHT**

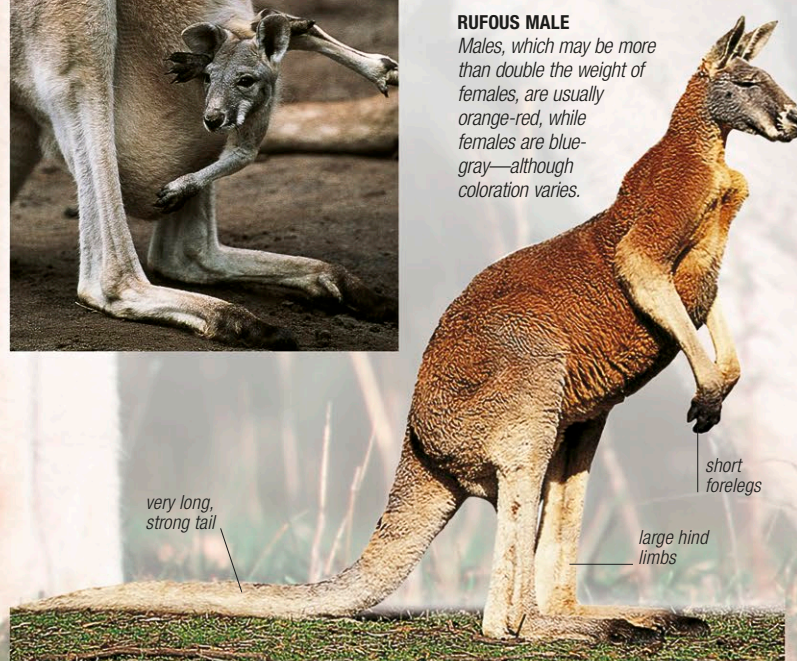
Fleeing from danger, the red kangaroo bounds on its hind legs. It can reach 30 mph (50 kph) for short periods.

IN MOTHER'S POUCH

The young spends 7.5 to 8 months in the pouch, before making its first foray outside. It becomes independent when a year old.

**RUFOUS MALE**

Males, which may be more than double the weight of females, are usually orange-red, while females are blue-gray—although coloration varies.



very long,
strong tail

short
forelegs

large hind
limbs